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Session 3 — Registration and Login System

Objective

Build the user authentication system: registration, login, session management, and secure password storage.

1. Why Authentication?

Authentication ensures that each student sees only their own modules. Without a login system, anyone could see or delete anyone else's data. A session in PHP keeps the user logged in as they navigate between pages.

2. Key Concepts

- **Registration:** creating a new account and saving it in the users table
- **Login:** verifying email + password and starting a PHP session
- **Session:** a way for PHP to remember who is logged in across pages
- **Password hashing:** storing a coded version of the password (not plain text) for security

Use PHP's built-in functions for security:

```
// Hash the password before saving:
$hash = password_hash($password, PASSWORD_DEFAULT);

// Verify at login:
password_verify($password, $hash);
```

3. Practical Tasks This Week

- 1 Create register.php with an HTML form (name, email, password)
- 2 Connect the form to PHP and save the user in the users table
- 3 Hash the password with password_hash() before saving
- 4 Create login.php with an HTML form (email, password)
- 5 Check credentials with password_verify() and start a PHP session
- 6 Redirect to dashboard.php after successful login
- 7 Create logout.php that destroys the session and redirects to login

Expected Result by End of Week

- ✓ A new user can register and their data appears in the users table
- ✓ A registered user can log in successfully
- ✓ The PHP session is started and the user is redirected to the dashboard
- ✓ Incorrect login shows an error message

Advice & Common Mistakes to Avoid

- ! Always validate form inputs — check that fields are not empty
- ! Never store passwords as plain text — always use `password_hash()`
- ! Check if the email already exists before registering a new user
- ! Use `session_start()` at the top of every page that uses sessions
- ! Protect your pages: redirect to login if the user is not authenticated

Prepare for Next Week

- Be ready to implement the module management (CRUD) system
- Review INSERT and SELECT SQL statements
- Think about how the module form will look